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end-users to choose, and more often than not, we end up with a gadget that has features we will never use, or offers everything but the features we really wanted.

A common example is that of smartphones that have so many features and complicated menus that one cannot figure out how to turn the damn T9/dictionary function off, so as to be able to type in our Indian names in SMSes. Don't you miss your old phone now?



Incompatibilities Abound

It's bad enough that technologies have such short life-spans; convergence just compounds this problem by orders of magnitude. Just when you're getting used to one

technology, they change everything and you are stuck with outdated and incompatible hardware.

The Laser Disc (LD) player was the best example. It could play VCDs, Audio CDs and Laser Discs (LDs were the size of vinyl records, and about twice as heavy). Those of you who bought one, will remember that within a few years, some genius decided that LDs were too big and awkward to carry about, so they invented the DVD. Now you are stuck with an LD player.

Want to watch the latest movies? Pop them into the DVD player and enjoy Dolby surround sound. Want to watch Pink Floyd's *Pulse* concert, which you have on LD? Climb up to the attic, sift through 20 boxes, pull out the LD player, wipe off two inches of dust, connect it to the TV, realise that it doesn't work, spend four days trying to find an engineer who has at least heard of an LD player, leave alone fix it, give up, pack it all up, put it back again, and go out and buy *Pulse* on DVD! It's just not fair!

Let's not forget that even our two-year 'old' DVD players are on the brink of extinction, what with Blu-ray and a host of other formats that promise utopia on the horizon!



Upgrade Mania

Technology has always been fickle; what's in and cool today will not necessarily be the norm tomorrow. Hardware changes are especially irritating, as it usually

involves you having to take a day off from everything and going out and buying new parts for something that actually works just fine!

Again, as with the mobile phone example, you bought a phone less than two years ago, and it boasted of Bluetooth then. Today, you find it actually has Bluetooth version 1.0, whereas the standard today is 1.1.43.5572.x, or something equally innane. So you can't connect to certain newer devices. Doesn't that just want to make you want to tear your hair out?

And it's not like you can just pop in a new card and have it all work again. Take your phone to an 'authorised service centre' and tell them that you want to have your phone upgraded to Bluetooth 1.1.43.5572.x, and they start shifting away from you uneasily, and signal the receptionist to call the loony van!

Even if that doesn't happen, the cost of upgrading a chip inside your mobile is almost 80 per cent

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